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AP

MAMDANI TAKES OATH AS NEW YORK CITY MAYOR

New York Attorney General Letitia James, left, administers the oath of office to mayor-elect Zohran Mamdani, as his wife Rama Duwaji looks on, in New York, yesterday. The ceremony took place at a historic, decommissioned subway station in Manhattan. Mamdani, a Democrat, was sworn in as the first Muslim leader of America's biggest city, placing his hand on a Quran as he took his oath.

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Community-led virtual authority launched

In a first, skilled members of UAE community will manage authority

ABU DHABI

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan has directed the launch of the Community-Managed Virtual Authority, a new initiative inspired by the vision of the UAE's Founding Father, the late Sheikh Zayed, to enhance the role of skilled individuals in shaping the nation's future.

The announcement coincides

with the conclusion of the Year of Community.

The Community-Managed Virtual Authority adopts a non-traditional approach to government that places community participation at its core.

Full responsibility

Under this model, skilled members of the UAE community will, for the first time, assume full responsibility for managing an authority. A Director General and team members will periodically be assigned to lead and run the authority for fixed terms, with a remit to develop meaningful products that deliver lasting benefit to the nation and its people.

The UAE is pioneering this innovative model as part of the President's broader vision to empower and invest in people and harness their capabilities for the benefit of society.

The Community-Managed Virtual Authority adopts a flexible appointment process based on clear criteria of competence, expertise, and the ability to contribute effectively to the authority's objectives.

The authority aims to attract diverse groups of skilled Emiratis to participate on a rotating basis, including experts, specialists, professionals, academics, youth, entrepreneurs, and retirees with significant experience.

— WAM

40 dead, 100 hurt in Swiss resort NYE fire

BLAZE OF 'UNDETERMINED ORIGIN' BREAKS OUT IN POPULAR TOURIST BAR

CRANS-MONTANA

A fire ripped through a crowded bar in the luxury Swiss ski resort town of Crans-Montana as revellers rang in the New Year, killing and injuring several people, police said early yesterday.

Police, firefighters and rescuers rushed to the popular resort, one of the top-ranked ski destinations in Europe, with Swiss media reporting the toll could soar into the dozens.

Swiss daily *Blick* cited a doctor at the scene suggesting that the death toll could be in the "dozens". Regional daily *Le Nouvelliste* also said its sources were describing "a heavy toll", with "around 40 dead and 100 injured".

Emergency unit full

The emergency unit at the main hospital in the Wallis was full, with the injured being transported to various hospitals across Switzerland. More than a dozen victims had been transported to the Zurich University Hospital in northern Switzerland, while at least 22 people suffering from serious burns had been taken to the main hospital in Lausanne, and six had been taken to Geneva, the Keystone-ATS news agency reported.

The "fire of undetermined origin" broke out in a bar popular with tourists, police in the Wallis canton in southwestern Switzerland said in a statement.

A tourist from New York filmed bright orange flames pouring from the bar, and told AFP he saw people running and screaming in the dark.

A police spokesman named the bar as Le Constellation, which has a capacity of 300 people and another 40 people on its terrace, according to the Crans-Montana website. The spokesman said some 100 people had gathered there for New Year celebrations.

A tourist from New York filmed bright orange flames pouring from the bar, and told AFP he saw people running and screaming in the dark.

"Several people lost their lives and others were injured," the police statement said, describing the incident as "serious" and adding that "a major emergency response is underway".

Swiss media suggested that the fire may have started when pyrotechnics were used during a concert, but police said the cause was unknown. Police spokesman Gaetan Lathion told AFP earlier there had first been an "explosion of unknown origin" at around 1:30am (0030 GMT) at Le Constellation.

— AFP

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